

Kings rule, but their reigns also come to an end. Shah Rukh Khan sat on the throne for nearly two decades, winning hearts, whether he was helping a young woman get on to a train, or dancing on top of it. He was everyman, and God. You laughed when he laughed, cried when he cried, felt a frisson of patriotism as he led a young Indian women hockey team to the rousing anthem of "Chak de! India" or returned home to Swades. You were happy when he fell in love, distraught when he was heartbroken. *Pathaan* co-star John Abraham put it best: "Shah Rukh is not an actor anymore, he is an emotion."

For a while, though, that empire seemed shaken. Fans were unforgiving of mistakes, and cold to his experimentations. Great power, Khan learnt, came with great responsibility. Vulnerability too. The end seemed nigh. But, four years later, SRK is back. As Badshah 2.0. In the face of all challenges, personal or professional. Defying controversy, and age. And his fans can't have enough.

It was evident at the Taj Land's End hotel where his staunchest supporters from across India had gathered in late January to hail the return of their king. Chants of "We love Shah Rukh" and "*Bachche, Buddhe aur Jawan, sab dekhenge Pathaan*" rang in the room. Young women sported T-shirts with his face. Men danced uninhibitedly to "Jhoome Jo Pathaan", the song from the movie that has become a hit. Made on an estimated budget of Rs 250 crore, *Pathaan* has so far collected Rs 925 crore worldwide, and is the first Hindi film to breach the Rs 400 crore mark at home. Its success has revitalised not just Khan's career but also the Hindi film industry, which in recent years has been losing its audience to southern films dubbed in Hindi. It has even brought footfalls back to the struggling single-screen cinemas. *Pathaan* is Khan's first blockbuster since *Chennai Express* in 2013. His Bandra neighbours—Salman and Aamir—registered five of the top 10 biggest Hindi films in India in the past decade. With *Pathaan*, order is restored. Or, as an enthusiastic fan said, "SRK and Bollywood are back." Abraham would correct him: "He had just gone for a loo break."